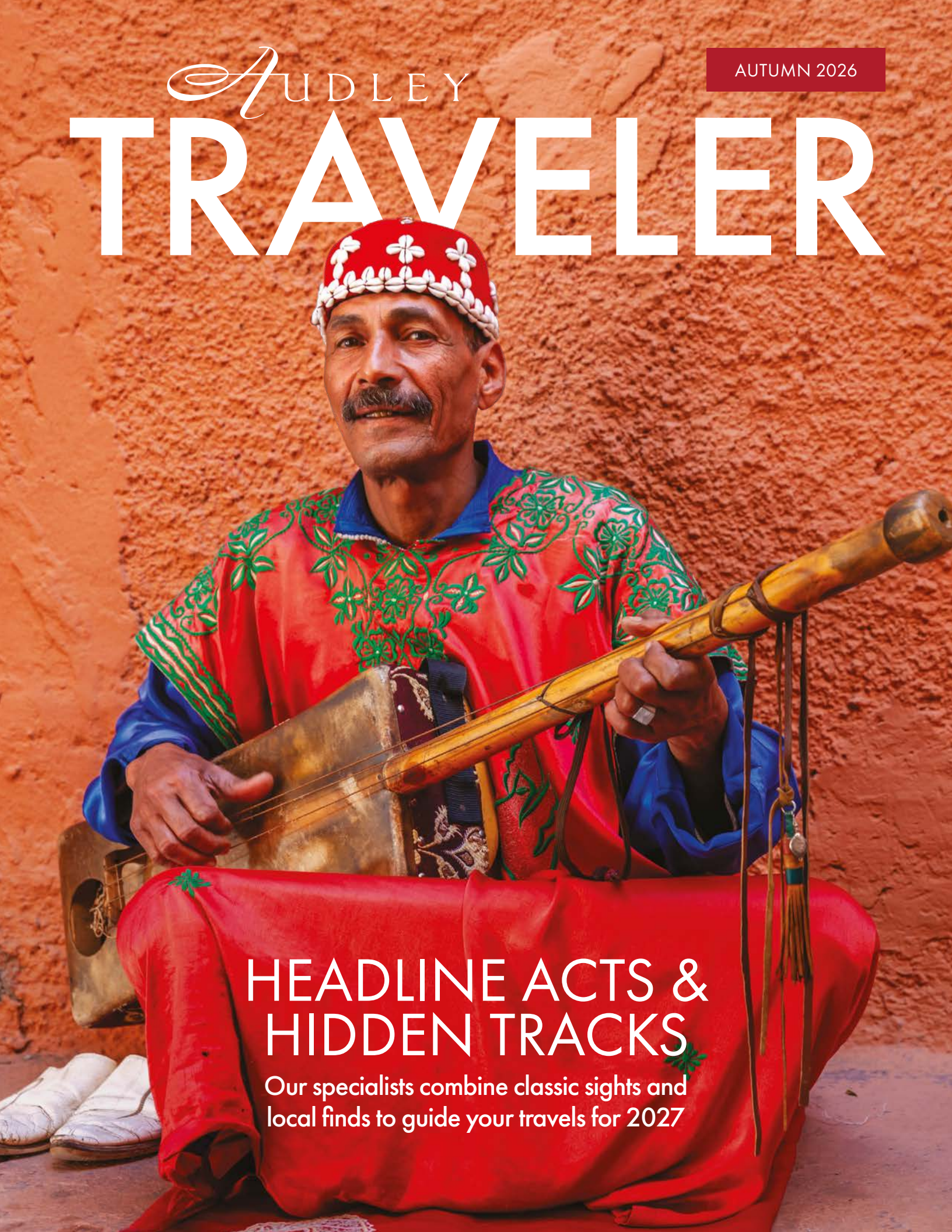
AUTUMN 2026

AUDLEY TRAVELER

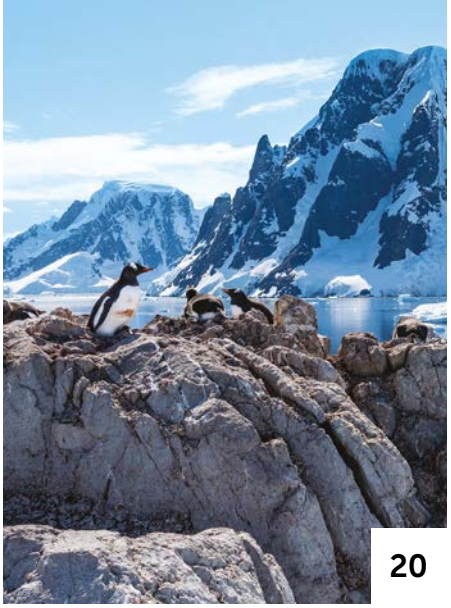


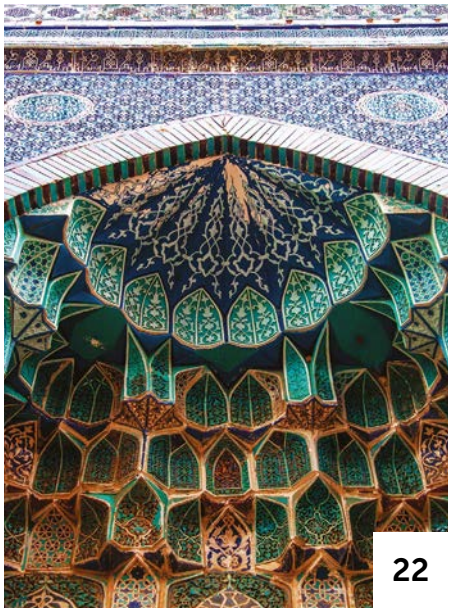
HEADLINE ACTS & HIDDEN TRACKS

Our specialists combine classic sights and local finds to guide your travels for 2027


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34 Big Five alternatives
You've heard of Africa's Big Five. Now specialists Matt and Sophie introduce the wildlife superstars of India and Borneo.

40 Two sides to...
The thrill of adventure or a slower-paced wildlife odyssey? We look at two ways to experience the wilds of Patagonia.

Welcome



As we move into autumn, I know many of you, like me, take joy in looking ahead to a new year of travel. In *Audley Traveler*, we often enthuse about destinations that fly under the radar, like Uzbekistan, which you can read all about on page 22. But we know that sometimes you also have your sights (and hearts) set on the big hitters. The good news is you can cross off the headline acts while also enjoying lesser-known but equally rewarding experiences wherever you go in the world. Six specialists reveal how on page 14.

South Africa is one of the A-list destinations we've featured, but there are plenty of other places to get your wildlife fix. On page 34, specialists Matt and Sophie reveal alternative Big Fives to scout out in India and Borneo.

Finally, we've recently unlocked more destinations for you to explore with us, including Finland. Beth, from our Europe team, has recently visited Lapland and shares her winter wonderland experience on page 4.

I hope you enjoy reading this edition.

Heather Heverling
President & Managing Director

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Contributors



Amanda
Italy specialist
Amanda spent years working, studying art, and embracing la dolce vita in Italy, making her well placed to share how to get the most from a trip to the country's heel. Turn to page 30 for her food, wine, and cultural recommendations.
The best wrong turn you've taken?
In Venice we headed for a drink at the Aman hotel — where an elopement was happening. My friend and I ended up standing in as honorary bridesmaids.

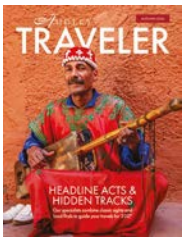


Finley
Uzbekistan specialist
After a backpacking trip through Central Asia, Finley was captivated by Uzbekistan's architecture. He recently returned to experience it with a guide and, on page 22, he lets you in on the local secrets he uncovered.
The best wrong turn you've taken?
I went to the wrong train station in Tashkent, but ended up swapping stories with the taxi driver who rushed me to the right one — and I caught a nicer train.



David "Woody" Wood
Polar expedition leader
Woody first experienced Antarctica over 20 years ago, yet he remains in awe of its ever-changing nature. On page 20, he describes the moments — both big and small — that leave a lasting impression of the continent.
The best wrong turn you've taken?
While sailing in the Arctic, I rounded one more headland than usual and spotted a polar bear helping her cub get ashore.

On the cover



Street musician in Marrakesh, Morocco
You can read about combining the cacophony of Marrakesh with a trip through Morocco's quieter, wildlife-rich south in our article on page 15. Contact our Morocco specialists on **855-820-8510** or request a copy of our worldwide brochure at www.audleytravel.com/brochures.

NEW FINNISH LAPLAND

By Beth, from our Europe team



"As the berry-red blanket on my lap gained a light dusting of snow, our one-antlered reindeer plodded through the fir forest, creating a soundtrack of crunching snow to cut through the silence. 'He's halfway through shedding,' my guide told me. But as much as I loved getting to know this gentle (albeit strong-willed) creature, I couldn't help but think about the huskies I'd met just before our ride. Eight-week-old puppies with wispy fur and droopy ears that my guide had arranged for me to see after I'd told him about my beloved golden retriever, Callie, back home." Inspired? Contact our Finland specialists on **855-415-1829**.



TEOTIHUACÁN, MEXICO

By Chris, Mexico specialist



"'The place where the gods were created.' That's the meaning of Teotihuacán, an ancient Mesoamerican city dominated by the Pyramids of the Sun and the Moon. I think it's fitting to witness them from the sky, bathed in early-morning light. Once the roaring burners have lifted you to a lofty vantage, your pilot hands you a glass of sparkling wine to toast the view — one that was shaped some 2,000 years ago by a people who are still shrouded in mystery. Your guide will later piece together what's known about them, as well as the Aztecs who found and named the abandoned city, as you walk among its ruins."

Inspired? Contact our Mexico specialists on **855-821-8188**.


Sky
Sky

ESCAPE ROUTES

TRAVEL NEWS | CHECK IN | WHERE TO GO IN...



WHAT'S NEW

Discovering your Italian roots

More and more of you are asking us to help you explore your ancestry when you travel — particularly to Italy. You might want to walk the streets your family once called home, connect with the traditions, food, and way of life that define your heritage, and even meet long-lost relatives. We're now working with specialist guides in Sicily, Naples, and Calabria who can conduct in-depth research into your family history, from sourcing genealogical records to creating a map of your lineage. Using the guides' findings as a starting point, we'll create a trip that might include visiting your ancestral villages, tracing migration routes, or uncovering the stories behind the names in your family tree. Contact our Italy specialists on **855-293-4890**.

HELLO, FINLAND

From snow-blanketed forests to lakeside saunas, Finland has long stood out to us as a definitive Nordic destination — and we're thrilled to be adding the country to our destination portfolio. You can visit the capital, Helsinki, for a taste of the Finnish food scene before heading deeper into Finnish Lapland, where you might sled with huskies, visit Santa with your family, and spend your nights in a glass igloo beneath the northern lights. Contact our Finland specialists on **855-415-1829**.





MALAYSIA BY RAIL

Southeast Asia specialist Sophie recently spent three nights aboard Belmond's *Eastern & Oriental Express*, a train that she says "felt like going back in time". The route begins and ends in Singapore, passing through Taman Negara National Park's tropical rainforest, where you can learn techniques from a nature photographer, and calling in at Penang's George Town, which you could explore from the back of a Vespa. Fine dining and a personal butler service enhance your journey. Contact our Southeast Asia specialists on **855-827-3440**.



VOYAGES OF TASTE

We're now offering land-and-sea voyages with Oceania Cruises, a luxury, adults-only cruise line that puts as much emphasis on onshore experiences as it does your time on the water. On board, you can enjoy chef-led culinary classes and talks from experts, while extended port stays mean you'll have your pick of tours drawing on local knowledge, particularly in the world of cuisine. Dining, too, is a standout, with several gourmet restaurants and a reputation for some of the finest food at sea. Contact our cruise specialists on **855-236-7242**.



BOATING IN BODRUM

Whitewashed houses sit beside the Aegean Sea and stone ruins form an Ancient Wonder of the World, making Bodrum feel almost Greek, despite being on Turkey's southwest coast. Laid-back and sandy-shored, the peninsula is a strong contender for a trip finale, and now you can unwind in true Bodrum style: aboard a gulet — a type of wooden sailing boat, crafted in the region's shipyards for centuries. Your captain will steer you to quiet coves, where you can swim, snorkel, and sip Turkish wine. Contact our Turkey specialists on **855-415-3309**.

Through Her Eyes

Our partners in India have recently introduced *Through Her Eyes*, an initiative focused on creating travel experiences across the country led by women, for women. The seasoned all-female team have curated a collection of immersive activities across 29 cities, bringing the country's culture, art, food, and landscapes to life, from cooking and dining with a local family in Udaipur to joining a morning rooftop yoga session in Bateshwar. All are designed to help you meaningfully connect with local women, whether that's expert guides or tuk-tuk drivers — and conversations are encouraged so you can find out more about their lives. Contact our India specialists on **855-750-4065**.



CHECK IN

Heritage stays

From palaces to former sponge factories, these historical stays have stood the test of time, becoming destinations in their own right.



The royal treatment
Taj Lake Palace, India



UNION ØYE, SUNNMØRE ALPS

Why unpack here?
You'll find Union Øye nestled in a tiny, unassuming hamlet, perched at the end of Norangsfjorden. A grand dame built for the glitterati of the late 1800s, the hotel makes an elegant base if you want to explore the fjords and peaks that surround it, following in the footsteps of emperors, poets, composers, and explorers.

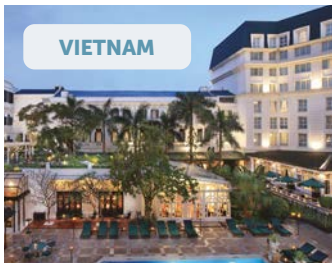
The best bit?
Every moment in the manor feels like a step back into the belle époque. You might join the cellar master for a tasting of rare wines, enjoy afternoon tea in the salon, or sip aperitifs in the Palm Room, beneath crystal chandeliers. Inspired? Contact our Norway specialists on **855-243-0748**.



TAJ LAKE PALACE, UDAIPUR

Why unpack here?
Built in 1746 by Maharana Jagat Singh II, Taj Lake Palace seems to command the city of Udaipur. The white, three-story edifice rises from Lake Pichola, with the waters lapping beneath bedroom windows. Inside, you'll find suites equally as opulent, decorated with semi-precious stones and stained-glass windows.

The best bit?
Your first sight of the hotel is from the water as you approach on a small boat, shaded by a gilded canopy. On arrival, you're greeted by your butler and led to your room through a leafy courtyard once reserved for Mughal royalty. Inspired? Contact our India specialists on **855-750-4065**.



SOFITEL LEGEND METROPOLE, HANOI

Why unpack here?
Welcoming people to Hanoi's French Quarter since 1901, this hotel continues to bring the city's history to life. In fact, you can stay in one of three suites named after famous past guests, including the room where Charlie Chaplin spent his honeymoon in 1936. A spa, pool, and four restaurants further enhance your stay.

The best bit?
Each evening, a historian-guide leads an exclusive tour of a restored wartime bunker. Discovered buried beneath the hotel's grounds, it was once used to protect guests from air raids in the 1960s and 1970s. Inspired? Contact our Vietnam specialists on **855-397-2971**.



BRATSERA HOTEL, HYDRA

Why unpack here?
In Greek, "bratsera" refers to the vessel used by sponge divers, an apt name for a hotel whose history as a sponge factory goes back to the 1860s. Today, you'll see this character reflected in the building's preserved details, from rough-hewn wooden beams and cedar staircases to whitewashed walls lined with antique maps.

The best bit?
Try classic Greek dishes with a modern twist, like spanakopita gyoza, at the hotel taverna, sitting beside Hydra's only outdoor pool. A nautical affair, it's easy to imagine divers gathering here, ouzo in hand after a day at sea. Inspired? Contact our Greece specialists on **855-561-4832**.

WHERE TO GO IN...

Ideas to inspire a trip in March or June

6 MONTHS



SOUTH KOREA

A giant bonfire, firework displays, boulder-carrying contests, and folk parades mark the arrival of spring on Jeju Island, off the mainland's southern coast. In addition to the celebrations, you'll find the weather mild enough for hiking the island's volcanic cones and craters, while later in the month, you can often see cherry blossoms and azaleas coming into bloom. Inspired? Contact our South Korea specialists on **855-828-8456**.



CHILE

As Patagonia's visitor numbers and strong winds ease off, changing leaves start to rouge the valleys of Torres del Paine National Park, hinting at autumn's arrival. You might also spot puma cubs as they emerge from their dens. Pair the great outdoors with wine tasting in the Colchagua Valley during harvest time, which ushers in grape stomping and lively festivities. Inspired? Contact our Chile specialists on **855-282-8123**.



SRI LANKA

March brings sunny skies and calm seas to the south of Sri Lanka, ideal for unwinding on Bentota's golden beaches or wandering the 17th-century coastal ramparts of Galle Fort. Meanwhile, on the other side of the island, in Wilpattu National Park, lower water levels draw wildlife to the wetlands, so you're more likely to spot elusive species like leopards and sloth bears. Inspired? Contact our Sri Lanka specialists on **855-753-5313**.

9 MONTHS



PERU

One of the best months to visit Peru, June heralds warm, sunny days, with crisp evenings at altitude, creating excellent conditions for hiking to Machu Picchu. Time it right, and you'll catch Inti Raymi in Cuzco, too — an all-singing, all-dancing ode to the benevolent Inca sun god. We recommend planning now to secure tickets for both the festival and the Inca citadel. Inspired? Contact our Peru specialists on **855-826-2543**.



SCOTLAND

Blooming wildflowers and mild weather set an idyllic scene in the Highlands in June, with snow lingering only on the highest peaks. It's a great time to hike Cairngorms' green valleys or search for crested tits in a Caledonian pine forest. You can also attend a gathering of the Highland Games, where centuries-old traditions take pride of place, from caber tossing to bagpiping. Inspired? Contact our UK specialists on **855-653-5623**.



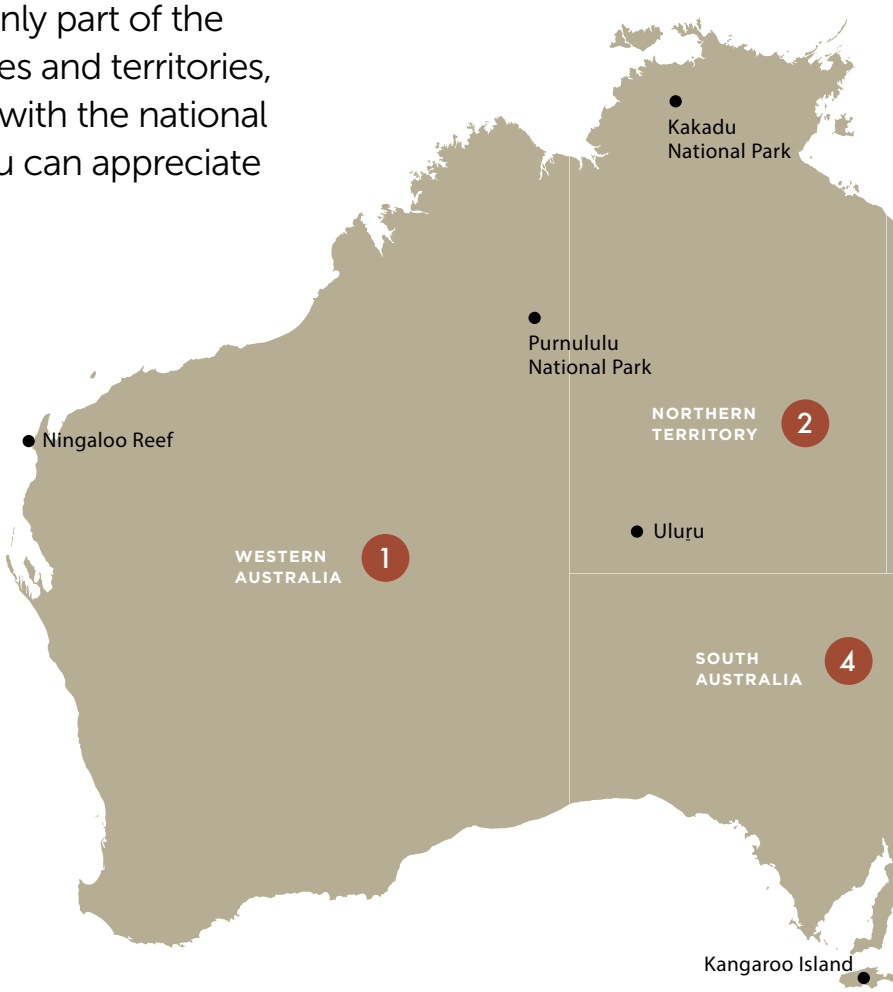
FRANCE

Visiting France in June usually means you'll beat the summer heat. The longer days are ideal for strolling Normandy's beaches and white chalk clifftops, where you can soak up some of the glorious light that inspired artists like Monet. Plan your stay around June 6th for D-Day commemorations that include firework displays, exhibitions, and parades along the coast. Inspired? Contact our France specialists on **855-276-3662**.

AUSTRALIA: FROM LANDM

Australia's signature landmarks are only part of the story. Across the country's eight states and territories, we've paired the best-known sights with the national parks that complement them, so you can appreciate a broader view of each region.





1. Ningaloo Reef & Purnululu National Park

Indian Ocean meets shell-white beaches at Ningaloo Reef. Here, you might snorkel with whale sharks on a naturalist-led boat trip. Then head inland to Purnululu, where a scenic flight reveals the Bungle Bungles' beehive-like domes and guided walks lead you to waterholes echoing with birdsong.



2. Uluṟu & Kakadu National Park

Rising from the Red Centre, Uluṟu is a cradle of Aboriginal culture. Beside the monolith, Anangu guides share their traditions over dinner as the sun sets. Further north, you can cruise Yellow Water Billabong, exploring Kakadu's stony plateaux, seasonal waterfalls, and crocodile-inhabited wetlands.



3. Great Barrier Reef & Daintree Rainforest

Join a boat trip so you can snorkel or dive with the Great Barrier Reef's kaleidoscopic sea life, or stay on a private island to access the coral straight from the beach. Adjacent to the reef, in the Daintree Rainforest, Kuku Yalanji guides show how culture and nature intertwine in this region.



4. Kangaroo Island & Flinders Ranges

A guided hike through Kangaroo Island's untamed forests gives you the inimitable chance to see platypuses in the wild. Back on the mainland, the Flinders Ranges is one of the world's oldest landscapes, where millennia-old rock art sits amid mammoth gorges particularly impressive from the air.

ARKS TO NATIONAL PARKS





5. Sydney & Blue Mountains National Park

Like a cluster of white sails billowing beside Sydney Harbour, the Opera House is one of Australia's defining icons. Visit usually off-limits areas on a backstage tour. Then join a local guide in the nearby Blue Mountains to encounter the Three Sisters, sandstone pinnacles jutting through a cobalt haze.



6. Canberra & Namadgi National Park

Surrounded by bushland, Canberra features a latticework of mid-century architecture and cultural institutions, including Parliament House. Southwest of the capital, Namadgi offers you a different perspective: guided bush walks past contorting gum trees and crevices where wallabies rest.



7. Great Ocean Road & Grampians National Park

Hugging a wave-cut coastline, the Great Ocean Road is particularly rewarding on a private tour, taking you past eucalypt forests, golden beaches, and the colossal Twelve Apostles sea stacks. Close by, the Grampians' trails wind around deep valleys, sloped escarpments, and ancient cave art.



8. Cradle Mountain & Freycinet National Park

Cradle Mountain's peak pierces the sky above a crystalline lake. Hike to its summit, or walk leisurely in a nearby rainforest for a chance to see wild wombats. To the east, you'll find Freycinet, where you can trek across the Hazards mountains with a guide, soaking up views over Wineglass Bay.

Get me there:

A 13-day trip for two, taking in Australia's Outback, cities, and reef, starts from $9,700pp.

View trip idea

Speak to one of our specialists on **855-753-5234**.

ICONS & INSIGHTS

The guidebook greats might get top billing, but they're rarely the whole picture. From Switzerland to Brazil, we share ways to combine the highlights with lesser-known finds for 2027.

Things that matter(horn) (from left to right) the Matterhorn; a Lavaux vineyard





Sleeping lions in the Kruger, the stony ramparts of China's Great Wall, Marrakesh's winding souqs… The world's best-known sights need no introduction — the challenge is finding out how to get the most out of them. Of course, our specialists know them well. They also know that some of the most memorable experiences happen away from the big hitters. Drawing on that expertise, they've paired guidebook classics with experiences that reveal a different side of these destinations. That might mean hiking in the Alps after sampling Swiss wines in a Lavaux vineyard. Or standing at the foot of *Christ the Redeemer* before exploring the dunes of Brazil's Lençóis Maranhenses National Park. After all, for travel in 2027, why choose between the headliners and hidden tracks, when you can have both?

SWITZERLAND

By Switzerland specialist Brianna



The Matterhorn steals the Swiss spotlight, but Lavaux's vineyards make for a compelling encore.

From the guidebook

The Matterhorn has been the star act of the Swiss Alps since climbers first set their sights on its summit in the 1860s. With its distinct shark-fin silhouette, it's a classic view for a reason, and for me, nowhere shows it off quite like Zermatt.

The town itself is compact and car-free, making it easy to stroll among the larch-wood chalets and storehouses-turned-restaurants serving fondue and raclette. But the real attraction remains the surrounding peaks. You can hike through high Alpine meadows, cross the nearby Gornergrat Glacier with a mountaineer, or take a gondola to Europe's highest cable car station for top-of-the-world views.

I also can't recommend enough arriving in — or departing from — the town aboard the *Glacier Express*. No matter the season, you can see the Alps' natural drama play out through ceiling-high windows as your train glides over narrow bridges and through mountain tunnels.

Beyond the guidebook

While Switzerland's chocolates and cheeses enjoy global prestige, the wine industry is one of its lesser-known delights — only a small percentage of Swiss wine ever leaves the country. For me, one of the best places to discover it is Lavaux, where vineyards line the shores of Lake Geneva in steep terraces against a backdrop of the Central Alps. Here, I can arrange for you to visit a private estate to sample local varieties like chasselas, a crisp, fruity white wine. The experience includes lunch, during which wines are paired with assiette valaisanne, a platter of air-dried meats, hard cheeses, and rye bread.

Get me there:

Combine Zermatt with a Lavaux winery visit on an eight-day trip for two that starts from $7,890pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our Switzerland specialists on **855-519-9843**.

CHINA

By China specialist Kristina



Pair battlements and Buddhism with a visit to the Great Wall and a monk-led tour of a monastery.

From the guidebook

While the old expression isn't true — you can't actually see the Great Wall of China from space — it remains a feat of engineering that more than lives up to its stratospheric reputation. There are several sections you can easily visit from Beijing, but I prefer the two-hour drive northeast to Jinshanling, where the monument receives far fewer visitors.

Here, some of the wall's best-preserved stretches tumble up and down the mountainside, sandy stone blocks sitting side by side like giant chess pieces. To appreciate its scale, it's worth allowing at least four hours to explore. You can take a cable car to the highest point or climb the original centuries-old stairways. Both are best done with a guide, who'll share tales of thwarted Mongol invaders and lead you to still intact 400-year-old watchtowers.

Beyond the guidebook

On the edge of the Tibetan Plateau stands Songzanlin Monastery, one of China's most important hubs of Vajrayāna Buddhism. Home to around 600 monks, it dominates the outskirts of Shangri-La. You can visit independently, but I think you get far more from the experience with a lama, who'll give insights into monastic life few ever see.

Then, in the Old Town, a guided tour offers you a glimpse into traditional Tibetan homes, with livestock housed below and family quarters above. Time it right and you'll reach the city's giant prayer wheel at dusk, when locals gather to set it in motion — a task that requires many hands.

Get me there:

A 19-day trip for two to China, including time in Jinshanling and Shangri-La, starts from $9,100pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our China specialists on **855-320-3380**.







Brick by brick
(pictured) Great Wall of China; (top right) Songzanlin Monastery; (bottom right) prayer wheel, Shangri-La



Turn on the light
Lamps for sale in a Marrakesh souq

MOROCCO

By Morocco specialist Sophia



From medina to wildlife-rich coast — a journey into Morocco's quieter south.

From the guidebook

With its lattice of souqs, Moorish architecture, and cacophony of daily life, Marrakesh is, in many ways, a microcosm of Morocco. I suggest navigating it with a guide first, either on foot as they teach you how to haggle for Amazigh rugs, or from a motorcycle sidecar, whizzing through narrow alleys and out into the palm groves. Then, go it alone and lose yourself in the twists and turns of the walled medina. It's almost a rite of passage.

Beyond the guidebook

The south of Morocco often flies under the radar, leaving its desert plateaux, palm oases, and unshowy souqs largely undiscovered by visitors.

For me, it reflects the most authentic version of Morocco. Plus, you can experience a side of the country that few consider: its wildlife.

Taroudant is touted as the Godmother of Marrakesh. You'll find similar red-mud walls and shady medinas, but with fewer crowds. I encourage you to slow down and peruse its stalls at your own pace — a luxury not always afforded in Marrakesh's hubbub. I've found saffron and argan oil to be particularly affordable here.

A little further south lies Souss-Massa National Park, a coastal ecosystem of sandbars, ponds, and reedbeds that shelters an array of creatures, including gazelles, oryx, and ostriches. Birdwatching is the biggest draw, and with an expert guide, you can spot black-crowned tchagras, purple herons, and the critically endangered northern bald ibis — the species that led to the area's protection.

Get me there:

You can visit Morocco's south, via Marrakesh, as part of an 11-day journey. A trip for two starts from $6,795pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our Morocco specialists on **855-820-8510**.



Wonder wall
Taroudant city walls



Ruffling some feathers
Northern bald ibis, Souss-Massa National Park



A bit of everything (clockwise from pictured) Wolfberg Arch, Cederberg; lions, Kruger; koesister

SOUTH AFRICA

By South Africa specialist Michaella



Cape Town plus Kruger is the classic calling card, but do the Cederbergs also beckon?

From the guidebook

If you visit one city in South Africa, it hands down has to be Cape Town. Sandwiched between mountains and the ocean, it never fails to take my breath away, and it doesn't disappoint when it comes to experiences, either. You can acquaint yourself with its melting pot of cultures on a private food tour, trying the likes of bunny chow (curry served in a hollowed-out loaf of bread) and koesisters (spiced syrup-infused pastries). I also suggest doing as the locals do by visiting a tidal pool for a refreshing morning dip with ocean views.

For a safari finale, fly to the Greater Kruger to spot the Big Five. I'll help choose an intimate lodge in a private reserve bordering the national park, where you'll see few others and have a wider mix of activities, from bush walks to night drives.

Beyond the guidebook

In addition to a full-blown safari, you could head into the Cederberg Mountains in the Western Cape, a landscape of twisted sandstone formations and knuckled peaks. I'll book you a room at Bushmans Kloof, set within its own nature reserve.

Here, guides lead you on wildlife drives and walks to spot rare Cape Mountain zebras, red hartebeest, and ostriches. They'll also introduce you to endemic fynbos flora, which is abundant in the Cape Floral Kingdom. If you go in August or September, you'll probably see South Africa's national flower — the king protea — in bloom, with its pink spiky petals.

The highlight for me, though, is setting eyes on ancient San rock art, some of which dates back 10,000 years. And Bushmans Kloof preserves dozens of examples. Your guide will explain how the illustrations were stained into the stone with natural pigments, like charcoal and clay. And, as you gaze up at them, you can still make out vivid depictions of man and beast.

Get me there:

Add time in the Cederbergs to an 11-day Cape Town, Kruger & Victoria Falls trip for two, starting from $14,310pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our South Africa specialists on **855-320-9545**.





BRAZIL

By Brazil specialist Humphrey



A feast for the senses in Rio, complemented by the otherworldly beauty of Brazil's only desert.

From the guidebook

"God made the world in seven days; the eighth he devoted to Rio de Janeiro." That's what the locals say of their city, a sprawling metropolis that spills down mountainsides before hugging the curves of Guanabara Bay. Most trips to Brazil start or end here. And, yes, I encourage you to peer up at *Christ the Redeemer* from his lofty perch and, of course, take a morning stroll along Copacabana Beach (though I prefer Ipanema Beach at sunset, when everyone claps at the day's close). I can also help you get to know the real Rio through street-art and food tours, live samba performances, or a behind-the-scenes look at Carnival.

Beyond the guidebook

Lençóis Maranhenses National Park looks like a child has swirled brilliant turquoise and white paint together — a coastal landscape of lagoon-filled dune valleys. Yet few visitors get to see it when they go to Brazil. Why? Because it's a bit of a mission to get there. But I think the three-hour flight and four-hour drive are worth it for the scenery. Plus, new luxury hotels are already starting to ramp up its popularity, so 2027 could be its last quiet year.

You can stay in one of the livelier towns outside the park, like Barreirinhas, where you'll be around an hour's drive from the bone-white sands and cachaça-clear waters. But I think there's something special about staying on the cusp of the park at ÓIA Casa Lençóis (it's well worth paying for the privilege). A working farm-turned-guesthouse, it's less than five minutes from the dunes, so you can enjoy the landscape for longer. From kayaking and quad biking to picnics on the sand and sunset visits, quieter swathes of the park become your playground for a few days.

Get me there:

Eight days for two, combining Rio and Lençóis Maranhenses starts from $7,750pp. Or you can enjoy a longer ten-day trip, including a stay at ÓIA Casa Lençóis, for $17,995pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our Brazil specialists on **855-823-0190**.







The bright side of life
(clockwise from pictured) Lençóis Maranhenses; Carnival drums; *Christ the Redeemer*, Rio

A guided tour with WOODY

An expedition leader for Quark Expeditions, Woody encourages you to explore the Antarctic Peninsula through its ever-changing landscapes, unexpected wildlife encounters, and the smaller moments that bring it all into focus.

Law was once the career plan for David "Woody" Wood, but he veered off course when he found his true calling: polar cruising. Originally from the UK, he moved to Australia in search of wilder landscapes, before a chance opportunity took him to Antarctica over 20 years ago. Since, Woody's taken on almost every role aboard a polar expedition ship, leading trips to both ends of the Earth. Join him as he takes you on a guided journey across the Antarctic Peninsula, from cruising through towering ice corridors to observing the antics of nesting penguins.



Ice breakers
Cruising by inflatable boat, Antarctic Peninsula

Antarctica never reveals itself the same way twice. One day might take you to huge sweeps of powdery snow, another to bare rock laden with lichen. Ice forms, it creaks under its own weight, then calves or melts away. Wildlife descends, breeds, nests, and moves on in droves. It's a constantly shifting environment, but it means you never get complacent.

As an expedition leader, my role is to shift alongside those changes: to shape every trip around what the landscape is doing, and to help you have the experience that brought you all this way, while also showing you the aspects you didn't even know to look for.

LIFE AT SEA

It all starts with a euphoric wave — figuratively and literally. Many of Quark Expeditions' Antarctica routes begin at the southern tip of Argentina, meaning you'll cross the Drake Passage, where three oceans collide. It's an often tempestuous stretch, but our purpose-built vessels are stabilized for a more comfortable journey. Besides, it's worth it for the view. The open ocean stretches endlessly beyond the horizon in every direction. Your only visitors are the albatrosses, using the wind from the ship to catapult themselves into the sky.

My focus during this time is to gain a good understanding of what makes you tick and to get an idea of your Antarctica agenda. That's the beauty of a small ship — rapport is built easily. When you're not out on deck, still awestruck by the scenery, there are plenty of talks to feed your curiosity — not just from me, but from ornithologists, glaciologists, and marine mammal specialists.

AN ICY OPENING ACT

The South Shetland Islands are where you'll usually catch your first glimpse of the Antarctic Peninsula. A bit of a highlight reel of what's to come,



Pole position
(pictured) gentoo penguins in Antarctica; (top right) Quark Expeditions' *Ultramarine*

they're a veritable feast of mountainous, glaciated scenery, icebergs of every shape and texture, and wildlife, from whales to terns, appearing where you least expect them.

Here, weather willing, we start getting off the ship and among the ice. The itinerary is never fixed — we're working with what the environment gives us — but experiences can range from hikes and kayaking to outings with a photography guide and helicopter flights over the bergs.

PASSAGE TO PETERMANN

One location in Antarctica I'm always excited about is Petermann Island. We travel there from the South Shetlands through the Lemaire Channel, a journey that feels like passing through a pinhole, with icy skyscrapers rising on all sides and, at its narrowest, icebergs lodged between them.

Then you're at Petermann, an island smaller than Central Park, and suddenly everything feels a whole lot more intimate. Something of a trove of landscapes and wildlife, it's a place I highly recommend exploring by land and water.

CLOSE ENCOUNTERS OF A WILD KIND

Humpback whales make for some of the most memorable chance meetings around the island, particularly in the krill-rich waters we seek out by inflatable boat. Whales are curious creatures, as interested in us as we are in them, often circling back for a closer look. We might even see them slap their tails or send up a great plume of spray if they're feeling particularly charismatic.

I can also point out when they start bubble-net feeding — corralling krill with rings of air before surging through the water in a sudden burst.

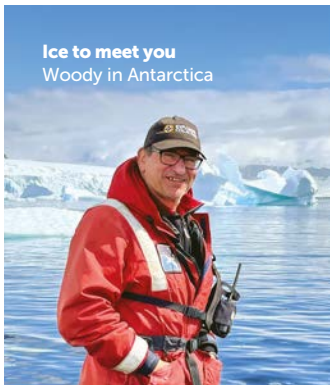
Back on land, Petermann is a major creche for hundreds upon hundreds of gentoo and Adélie penguins, and I can take you right into the heart of their Chaplin-esque antics.

I especially like to be a fly on the wall for the food chase, when chicks race after any food-carrying adults, parent or not. Or, if we're lucky, we might catch them at their most industrious, building pebble nests and pilfering materials from others.

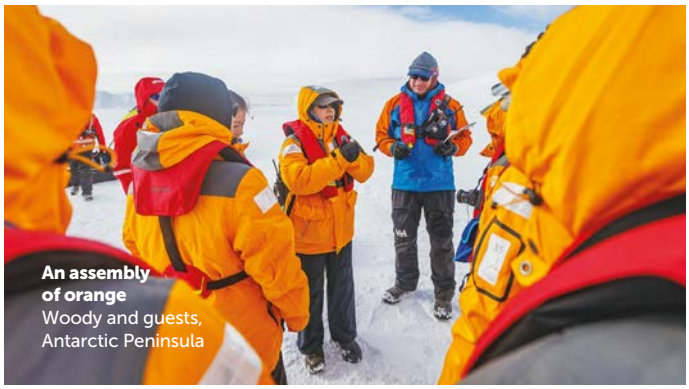
THE SMALL MOMENTS

Any tour with me also focuses on the quieter intervals, the ones that invite you to pause and really notice the little things. Take the ground, for example. You could be forgiven for thinking Antarctica is largely monochromatic, but as I'll show you, it's daubed with a much richer palette, from the greens of lichen and moss to pink algae and the rusty red tones of the rock.

Once you start tuning into those details, something else begins to come through: the stillness. Around Petermann, I often take a moment to cut the engine of our boat, so you can listen to the ice. Close up, it's gently popping all around us, while in the distance the glaciers might groan or crash — a dose of everything from the vast to minute, all at once.



Ice to meet you
Woody in Antarctica



An assembly of orange
Woody and guests, Antarctic Peninsula



SAILING WITH QUARK EXPEDITIONS

With small ships purpose-built for icy conditions and fewer passengers than larger cruise lines, Quark Expeditions offers an intimate way to explore the polar regions. As part of your voyage, meals and select drinks are included, alongside on- and offshore experiences that take you further into otherwise inaccessible landscapes.

From observing the glow of Iceland's northern lights to watching ice crash into the sea in Antarctica, memorable moments with Quark Expeditions might feel like chance encounters, but each experience has been carefully curated by experts in their field.

Get me there:

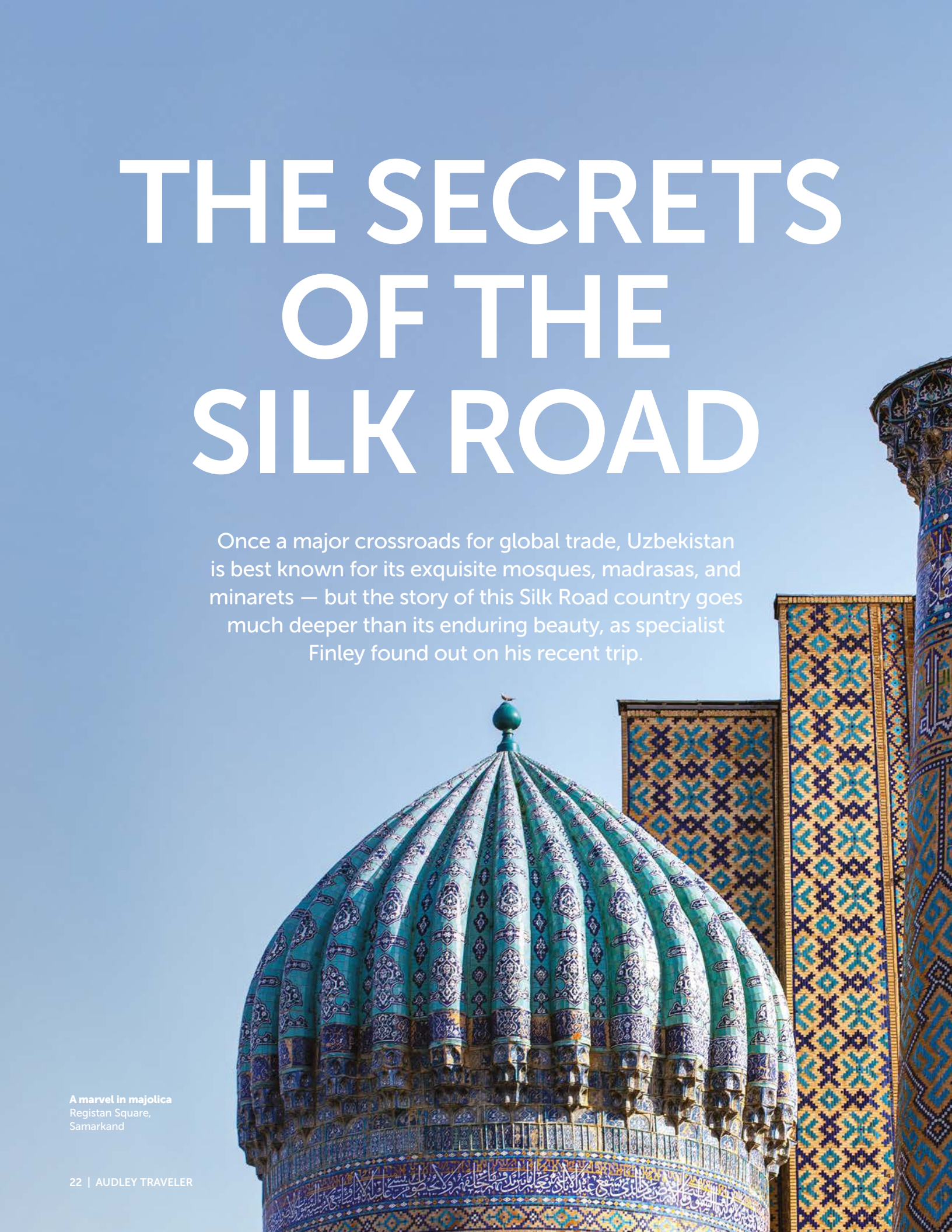
You can pair an Antarctic voyage with time in Buenos Aires. A 13-day trip for two starts from $16,820pp.

View trip idea

Inspired? Contact our cruise specialists on 855-236-7242.

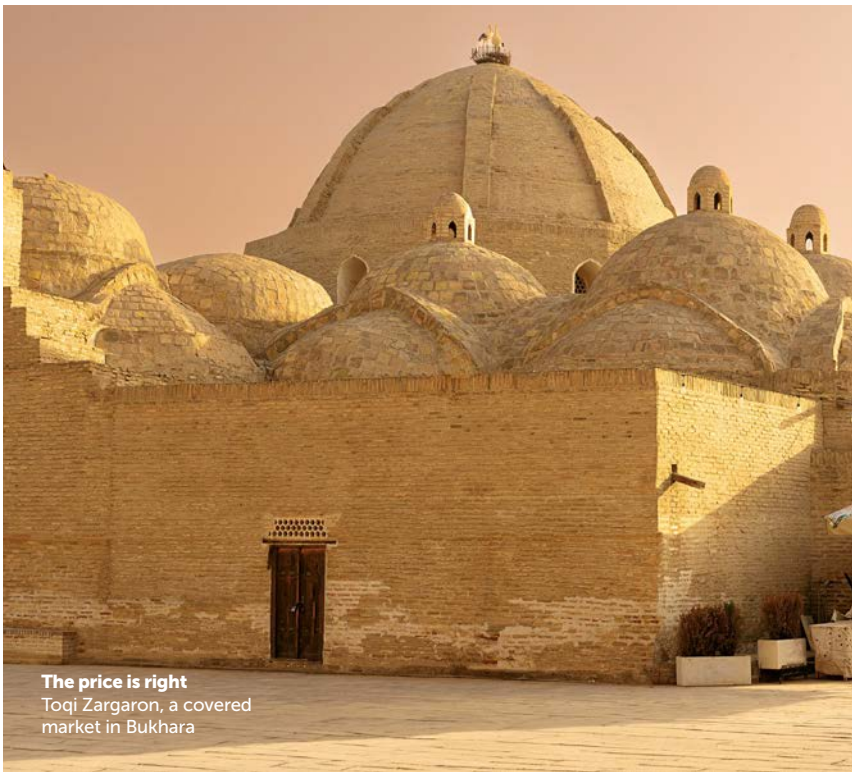
THE SECRETS OF THE SILK ROAD

Once a major crossroads for global trade, Uzbekistan is best known for its exquisite mosques, madrasas, and minarets — but the story of this Silk Road country goes much deeper than its enduring beauty, as specialist Finley found out on his recent trip.



A marvel in majolica
Registan Square, Samarkand



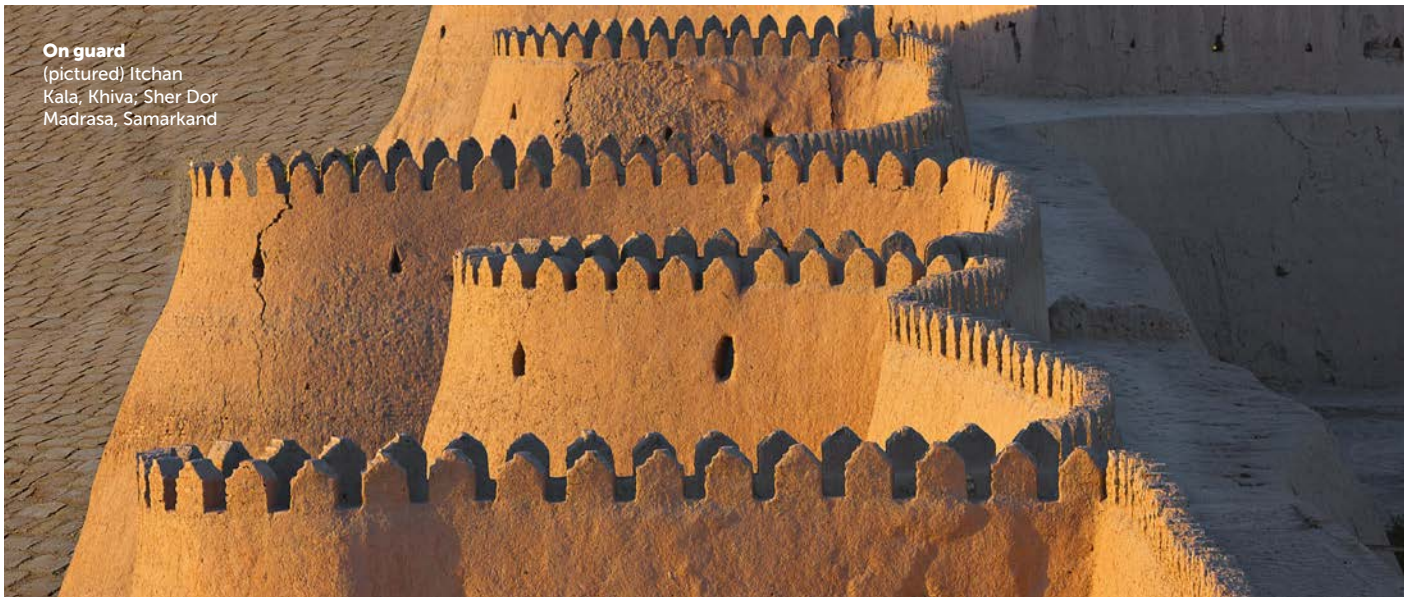


The price is right
Toqi Zargaron, a covered market in Bukhara

UZBEKISTAN SPECIALIST FINLEY



With a love for visiting destinations before they enter the spotlight, Finley first navigated the length of Uzbekistan on a shoestring budget, weighed down by an overstuffed backpack. Earlier this year, he returned to discover facets of the Silk Road that are easy to miss on a first pass. From hidden motifs on madrasa walls to Modernist metro stations worth the ride, he reveals how to get the most out of your trip.



On guard
(pictured) Itchan Kala, Khiva; Sher Dor Madrasa, Samarkand

"Do you notice anything unique?" asked my guide, Raykhona, sweeping her gaze across Registan Square, palms toward the cloudless sky. I'd stood in this very spot a couple of years before, but I still didn't know the answer she was looking for.

Craning my neck, I turned around slowly, the tilework of the arches and minarets swirling in patterns of blues, oranges, and yellows. It remains one of the grandest feats of architecture I've ever seen. Three madrasas (Islamic schools) face each other across a square, embellished with a riot of repeating patterns.

It all felt pretty unique to me. That's the draw of Uzbekistan: you won't find such quintessential Silk Road architecture anywhere else. For centuries, as far back as 207 BCE, this was a crossroads for traders moving silk, spices, and jewels along a global network of routes, sharing cultures and religions as they went.

"The tigers," she said, pointing up to the tiled archway looming to our right. "This is Sher Dor Madrasa, and it's a bit controversial." She went on to explain that the depiction of living beings — in this case, a pair of hybrid lion-tiger creatures prowling through a sea of blue, with a personified sun on their backs — defied Islamic tradition.

There's no one theory as to why the artists chose to include these beasts, but Raykhona posited a few. Perhaps they're mythical enough not to be considered living beings? Perhaps it's a nod to the solar lion found in Persian astrology? Perhaps they represent the pursuit of knowledge? Or maybe it was something else entirely, lost to history...

This was just one of many nuggets of wisdom Raykhona shared with me as we explored the country together — little details I'd missed the first time around.

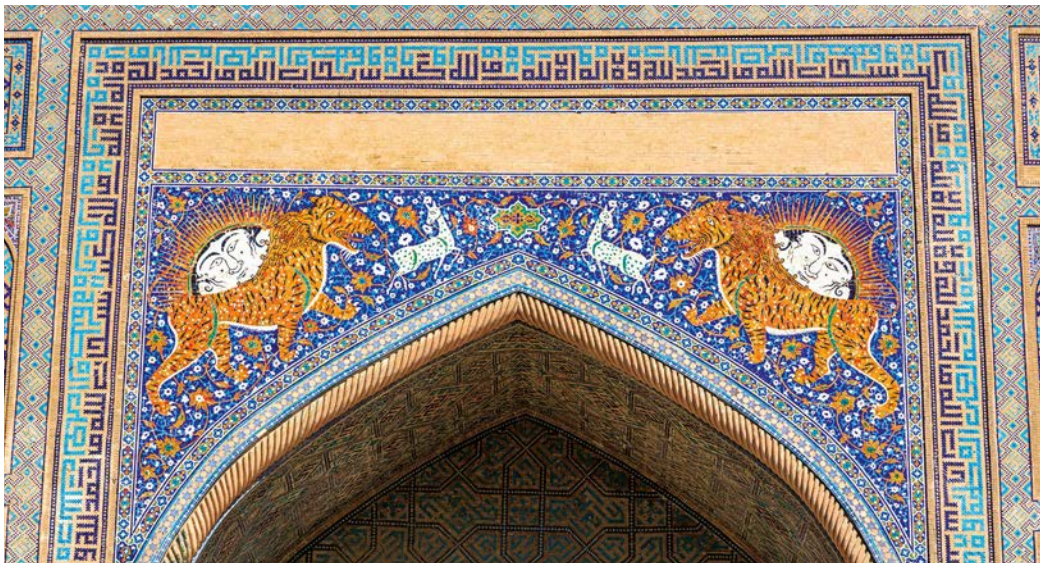
(A side note: It was a little unusual to have one guide for my entire Uzbekistan trip. Usually, you have a local show you around their hometown before your driver, who stays with you for your trip, takes you to the next city. There, another guide awaits. Each option has its merits, and I'll help you make the right choice for you.)

A WALLED CITY IN THE DESERT

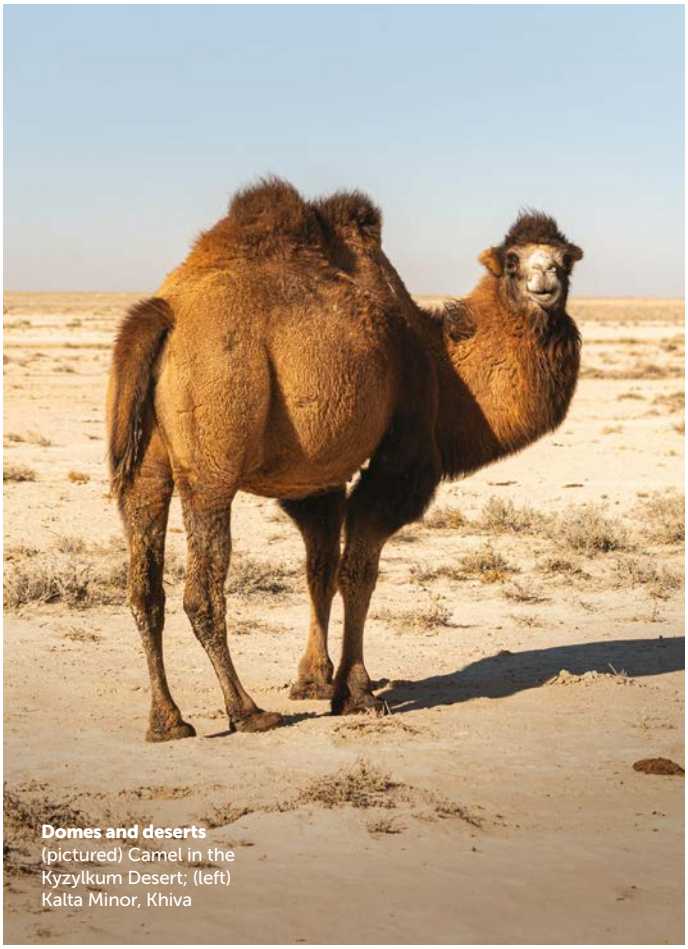
My first journey across Uzbekistan took me to Khiva, Bukhara, Samarkand, and Tashkent — in that order. And while my friends and I took a "go with the flow" attitude to our trip, it ended up being the route I now recommend the most. You can do it in reverse, but I prefer it this way because it takes you on a passage through time as well as geography.

I arrived in Khiva a little bleary-eyed from my flight, but admittedly less weary than the caravans of traders who once traipsed across the desert to reach the city hundreds of years ago. Standing outside the mudbrick walls of the citadel, Itchan Kala, with its notched parapets and curved watchtowers, I felt as though I was looking at a sandcastle — albeit one with a not-so-innocent past.

"Shall we go in?" Raykhona asked. She led me to the West Gate, where the







Domes and deserts (pictured) Camel in the Kyzylkum Desert; (left) Kalta Minor, Khiva

turquoise barrel of Kalta Minor peeked out from behind. "The minaret's unfinished," she said, but you'd never guess it just from looking. It was commissioned in 1852 by the region's monarch, Mohammed Amin Khan, who had lofty plans to create the tallest minaret in the Muslim world. But it was soon abandoned when he was killed in battle. I reached out to touch the smooth glazed tiles that wrapped around its entire form and thought, "Even incomplete architecture in Uzbekistan is impressive."

The citadel felt familiar from my last trip, but only in a hazy way. I could recall blue tiles shimmering against earthen walls and flourishes carved into wooden doors. But I was still lost the moment we walked into its labyrinthine streets. Raykhona knew every twist and turn, though, leading me to an array of majolica-tiled madrasas, mosques, and quiet courtyards. She also gave me the backstory of Orient Star Hotel, a former madrasa located beside Kalta Minor, where you can sleep in the compact rooms once occupied by scholars.

We finished the day by climbing to the top of Islom Hoja Minaret. From that vantage, looking out across the city, I reflected on the stories Raykhona had shared: tales of merchants and mathematicians, poets and artisans, but also of the slavers who traded not in silk but in people. Tens of thousands of them... It was a stark reminder that the Silk Road wasn't all beautiful buildings, scientific discoveries, and jovial bartering — it was a tool of oppression, too.

INTREPID JOURNEYS & DOMED BAZAARS

It took six hours to cross the Kyzylkum Desert from Khiva to Bukhara. There's not much to see, aside from scrubby sand and the occasional eagle soaring overhead, but it gave me time to think about those who'd taken a similar journey. Not in a nicely air-conditioned car like me, but on camel- or horseback — an arduous trek that could have lasted days or weeks. I could only imagine their relief at spotting the green of Bukhara's oasis on the horizon.

Like Khiva (albeit more sprawling), there are mosques and madrasas galore here. But it was the domed bazaars that caught my attention. During the 16th century, the city became one of the most important trading hubs along the Silk Road, and these bazaars were hives of activity. Walking through them today, you still get that sense of energy. Room-sized carpets and embroidered textiles hang from stone walls, while tables are laid out with brightly painted ceramics and ornate chess sets.

You can see several artisans at work beneath the vaulted ceilings, but I recommend taking an hour's drive out to the city of Gijduvan. Here, you can visit the pottery workshop of the Narzullaev family. They've been creating ceramics for centuries, passing down techniques across at least seven generations.

I watched how the potters turned lumps of clay into floral-patterned bowls — how the dull natural pigments turned bright and glossy once they emerged from the wood-fired kiln. It was a painstaking process, and I couldn't help but think of the sheer amount of work it must have taken artisans to adorn Uzbekistan's monuments with ceramics all those years ago.

THE JEWEL OF UZBEKISTAN

A few hours' drive from Bukhara is Samarkand, the Silk Road's pièce de résistance, where everything is larger, more elaborate, more vivid. It felt like a crescendo was building from the moment I set foot in Khiva, and it finally peaked as I stepped into Registan Square (where those polemic "tigers" reside).

The city has been continuously inhabited for more than 2,700 years. Conquerors and explorers have walked its streets, from Alexander the Great to Genghis Khan. It's awash with some of the most decorated mausoleums, mosques, and madrasas I've come across.

But the building that captivated me the most was less ornate: Bibi-Khanym Mosque, which dwarfs the city's other monuments at over 40 m (130 ft) tall. I'd glossed over it during my first trip, but Raykhona eagerly led me into the complex, sharing stories of its troubled construction — too much haste, too many earthquakes, and a touch of scandal.

From the outside, Bibi-Khanym feels almost understated. Instead of kaleidoscopic tiles, most of the mosque's exterior is two-toned: blue and sandy brown. And despite restoration efforts, you can see signs of disrepair: exposed bricks, missing tiles, cracked pillars that have toppled over... And yet, I welcomed a more unpolished glimpse of the Silk Road, less shiny but equally impressive — an indication of just how old these great monuments are.

FROM SOVIETS TO SKYSCRAPERS

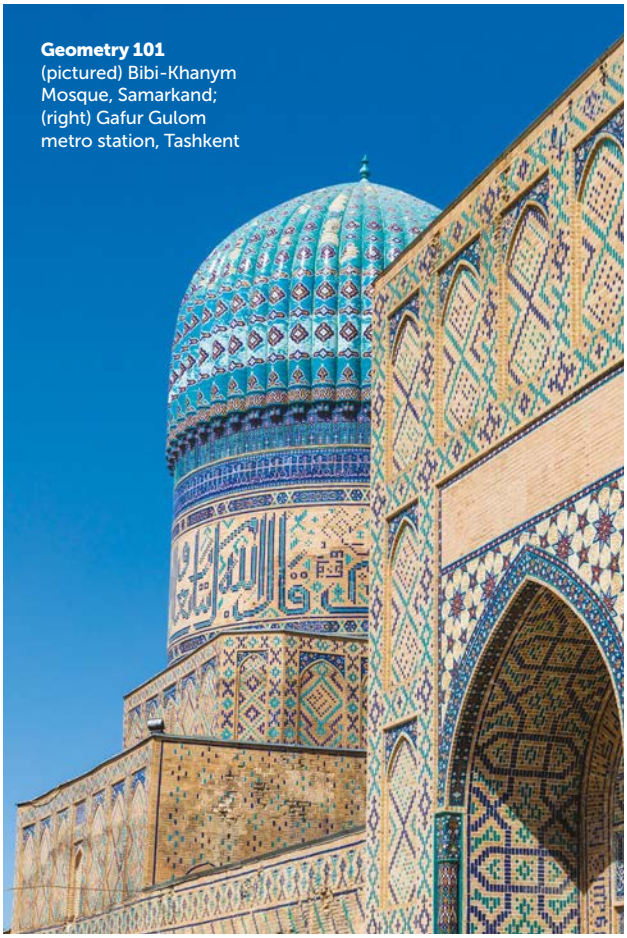
It almost felt like whiplash arriving in Tashkent on the high-speed train. Another stop along the Silk Road, the city is as old as those I'd just visited. Yet, it was remarkably different. Glass skyscrapers rose from manicured green spaces, an efficient metro service took me to strikingly Modernist stations, and huge Soviet buildings looked out onto grand public squares.

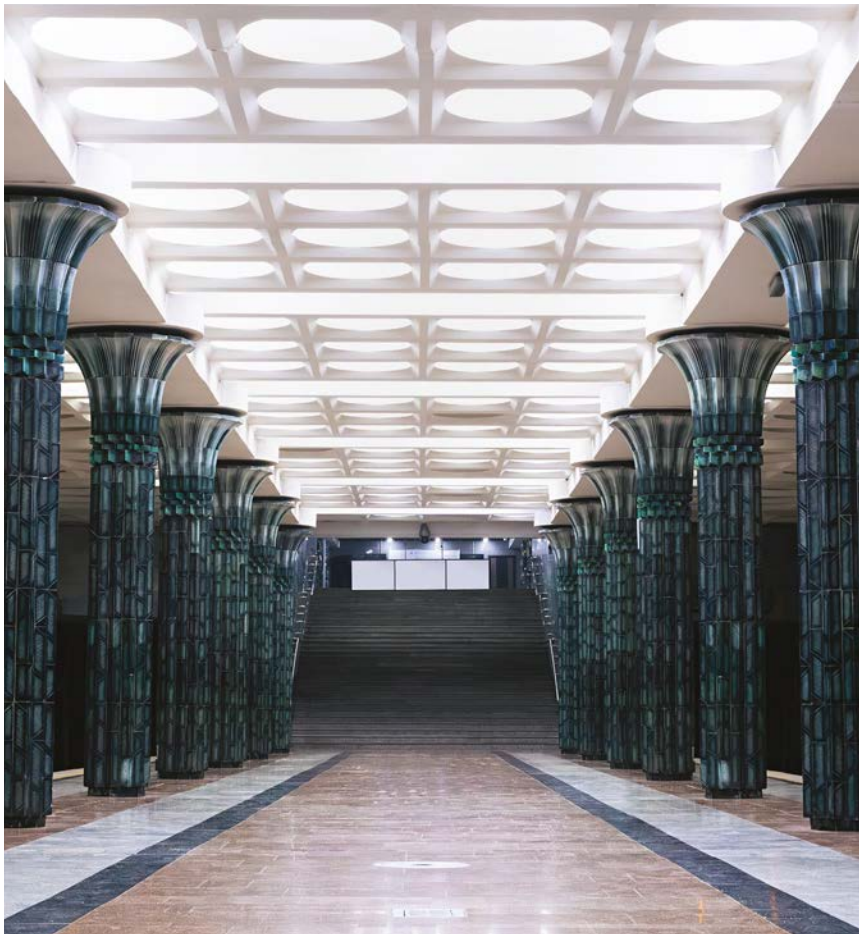
"An earthquake destroyed a lot of the city in 1966," Raykhona explained. It was the height of Soviet rule, and the destruction accelerated the rise of a new architectural style. But she was keen to point out the Uzbek flair within it, like the Islamic domes and geometric motifs that softened clean-cut Soviet lines.

Don't get me wrong, there are still tiled mosques and madrasas in Tashkent, including one that houses one of the oldest Qurans in existence. There are still markets, like Chorsu Bazaar, that brim with spices and handicrafts. And there are still carpeted chaykhanas (tea rooms) that hark back to those that hosted traders centuries ago. I even learned to bake flatbread the traditional Uzbek way in Tashkent, slapping the dough against the wall of the tandir (clay oven).

But, after a week or so of antiquity, it was the modernity that stuck with me in the capital. Like the space-themed Kosmonavtlar Metro Station, with its ceiling resembling the Milky Way (an ode to Soviet cosmonauts), and the cylindrical Panoramic Cinema, constructed from huge slabs of concave concrete.

It's a reminder that the Silk Road isn't just something frozen in the past. It's layered, complex — and still evolving. You just have to know where to look.





Geometry 101
(pictured) Bibi-Khanym Mosque, Samarkand; (right) Gafur Gulom metro station, Tashkent



High and low
(pictured) Tashkent City Park; (right) yurt, Kyrgyzstan



JOURNEYING FURTHER ON THE SILK ROAD

For a complete contrast, I suggest visiting Kyrgyzstan, too. It's only an hour's flight from Tashkent to the Kyrgyz capital of Bishkek. From there, you'll experience a completely different side of the region, from lakeside pastures where nomads graze their flocks to hiking trails that wind through mountain valleys. Visit them together in May or September, when the temperatures are cool enough in Uzbekistan but warm enough in Kyrgyzstan's mountains.

Get me there:

You can take in the mosques, madrasas, and modern architecture of Khiva, Bukhara, Samarkand, and Tashkent on a ten-day trip for two, starting from $5,750pp.

View trip idea

Speak to one of our Uzbekistan specialists on **855-561-5602**.


1


2


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6

TOP 6
FOR THE THRILL OF IT

Soaring heights and deep, dark nights — these experiences can tempt you out of your comfort zone or set an adventurous spirit ablaze.

1 *Alpine heli-hiking, Canada*
Recommended by Carla



As you soar over glacial valleys and steep-sided mountains, it becomes apparent just how expansive the Canadian Rockies are. Lifting off from Canmore, Alberta, you'll chopper out to a remote ridge above the treeline, before spending two to three hours hiking through alpine meadows, across streams, and along edges with 360-degree views over the peaks. When I went, there were no other visitors in sight — it was just me, our small group, and our guide, who imparted nuggets of wisdom about the park's geology and wildlife as we walked.

2 *Temple camp-out, Cambodia*
Recommended by Rachel



Preah Khan Kompong Svay is a centuries-old complex almost twice the size of the Khmer Empire's former capital, Angkor Thom. Its remote location means few visitors reach it, and I think the best way to experience it is by camping just outside. As the sun sets, you sit down to eat Khmer delicacies by candlelight, the occasional bat flickering in the shadows above. Then, once evening sets in, you head into the temple with a guide to explore by the light of a flaming torch, illuminating figures etched into the wall that predate carvings found at Angkor.

3 *Mapping the Milky Way, Chile*
Recommended by Piper



I've never seen the Milky Way as clearly as I did in the Atacama Desert. It shines particularly resplendent due to a fortunate mix of conditions: it's high, dry, and not many people live there (though the moon's light can make the stars dimmer, so I'll make sure you go on a day it rises late). The Atacameño people have been studying the stars for millennia, and a local guide can let you in on ancestral beliefs and wisdom during a campfire ceremony. Then, they'll wheel out giant telescopes so you can observe the constellations in pinpoint detail.

4 *Sunset summit, Indonesia*
Recommended by Glynn



Almost every vista in Indonesia is backed by the profile of a nearby volcano just waiting to be climbed. Mount Batur juts out of Bali's jungle, sitting between two merged calderas that contain a crescent-shaped lake. Others will tell you to aim for sunrise, but I'll time your two-hour climb to the summit for the day's quieter bookend, when the volcanic steam hits full height against a fiery sky and there are fewer hikers around. At the top, as you gaze across the landscape below, you'll dine on a Bali staple: eggs and noodles, cooked by your private guide in a volcanic vent.

5 *Canyoning in Utah, USA*
Recommended by Karl



Spend a morning, while the air's still fresh, among the rust-red rock formations that surround Zion National Park. Hiking is one way to do it, but I can pair you with a private guide who'll add a touch (or a lot) more adrenaline, if you like. They'll be on hand to literally show you the ropes as you rappel down rock faces, squeeze through narrow slot canyons, and scramble to lesser-known viewpoints. It doesn't matter whether you're a complete novice or an adventure pro — they'll choose locations based on your skill level and how confident you feel.

6 *Glacial steps, Iceland*
Recommended by Kelsey



You'll don crampons and carry ice axes for this journey into Vatnajökull National Park, which covers 14% of Iceland's landmass and shelters waterfalls, volcanoes, canyons, and ice caves. It's also the setting for the country's largest glacier, a vast edifice of blue-white ice that appears almost neon in some lights. I suggest hiking it with an expert guide, who'll lead you past sharp ridges and deep crevasses until you reach a wall of sheer ice. Then it's time to strap yourself into a safety harness and make your way, one careful step at a time, up the frozen face of the glacier.

48 Hours in ITALY'S HEEL

From millennia-old dwellings to family-run vineyards and generation-spanning traditions, specialist Amanda reveals how you can step into the local stories of Puglia and Matera.

ITALY SPECIALIST **AMANDA** 

DAY 1

8AM

A 17th-century farmhouse tucked among the olive groves of Puglia's Valle d'Itria, Masseria Montenapoleone is an ideal base for exploring the region. With plenty of walking ahead, I suggest your breakfast here is a leisurely affair. Served in the former stables, it's a spread of homemade produce, from freshly baked breads to eggs laid by the resident hens and the chef's signatures — dried-fig flan and cinnamon citrus "carpaccio" — washed down with a cappuccino or two.

9AM

Head 30 minutes west by car to Alberobello, a small settlement celebrated for its trulli, Puglia's hallmark architectural form. First conceived in the Bronze Age, these low-slung, whitewashed homes are capped by conical roofs, creating what looks like a miniature mountain range in the middle of the town.

The streets are at their quietest in the morning, when a local guide can help you decode the many symbols painted on the roofs as you wander among more than 1,000 trulli in the main quarter, Rione Monti.

I'd then make a beeline for Rione Aia Piccola, the more peaceful, residential side of town, to see how life among the trulli truly unfolds. It was here that I was once gifted several cockerel fischietti, rooster-shaped whistles given as a gesture of good luck.

1PM

I'm of the opinion that lunch is best seasoned with a dash of sea air. Fortunately, the coastal town of Monopoli is just a 30-minute drive north of Alberobello. After taking in its cobbled streets and Baroque churches, settle at a seafront trattoria. My recommendation? A panino con polpo: slow-grilled octopus and vegetables served on wood-fired flatbread.

3PM

For a final flourish, end your day in Ostuni, a nearby city that reminds me of a wedding cake, its white buildings wrapping around three hills before rising to a Gothic cathedral. As you navigate its alleyways, your guide will peel back the layers of the region's surprisingly gory history. On my visit, we heard tales of plague victims, Greek conquerors, and a 28,000-year-old fossilized skeleton discovered in a cave.







Pretty in Puglia
(from left) Trulli in Alberobello; Italian vineyard; Monopoli seafront





AMANDA SAYS

"I always end my time in Matera at Piazzetta Pascoli, overlooking the caves, with a limoncello spritz in hand."







Feast for the senses
(clockwise from opposite page top left) Puglian grapes; limoncello spritz; view of Matera; pane di Altamura; Altamura Cathedral

DAY 2

8AM

Begin your day in another Puglian culinary hotspot: Altamura. Just over an hour's drive from Valle d'Itria, the medieval town gave the world pane di Altamura, a semolina-based sourdough, which you can learn to prepare in a fifth-generation family-run bakery. I have to say, I've never known bread quite like it. Dense, sweet, and nutty, with a fluffy yellow middle and a thick, crisp crust, it pairs equally well with a creamy burrata or tangy orange marmalade.

After, I recommend taking time to explore the town — in particular the claustri, enclosed courtyards used by many different communities in the Middle Ages. In summer, I also love to duck into a nearby bar, so I can sit alfresco with a caffè leccese: espresso served over ice with a sweet almond milk.

11AM

Next, make your way out of Puglia to Matera, a city 20 minutes' drive south, in the Basilicata region. One of the world's oldest continuously inhabited settlements, it's a place where history is turned up to 11. Thankfully, with a knowledgeable guide by your side, you have a shortcut through the millennia.

Here, the star attraction is the Sassi di Matera, or old town, with its proliferation of cave dwellings carved into a limestone cliffside. Over half the local residents lived here until as recently as the 1950s — it's possible you could meet some who remember life among the rockface. However, times have changed immensely. What was once a deprived area with poor sanitation is now one of southern Italy's most sought-after addresses, with many of the former homes transformed into boutiques, bars, and hotels.

To see the caves at their most authentic, your guide will take you to Sasso Caveoso, where many dwellings remain much as they were 70 years ago, preserved as churches, artisanal workshops, and museums. For me, the standout here is the Cripta del Peccato Originale (Crypt of Original Sin), referred to as the "Sistine Chapel of rupestrian art", thanks to its eighth-century frescoes depicting scenes from the Old and New Testaments.

6PM

As you drift into evening, it's time for one more of Puglia's great traditions: wine. Back at the masseria, a sommelier will guide you through three local varieties. The estate itself grows susumaniello grapes, producing a dark, berry-rich wine that pairs beautifully with orecchiette pasta, another regional delicacy I always make a point of ordering for dinner.

Lastly, the vineyard is an ideal setting for an evening stroll. On my most recent visit, I was joined by a particularly hirsute guest — one of the farm cats, scampering through the vines as if giving me a tour.

Get me there:

Flight time:
Around nine hours direct from New York or around 13 hours from Los Angeles.

When to go:
Italy's heel is packed with culture year round, though April to October brings the best weather and the fullest range of experiences.

Start planning:
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Move over, Big Five

They might be the Rolling Stones of the animal kingdom, but Africa's Big Five aren't the only five-piece sensation deserving of your attention. Move aside, lion, leopard, elephant, buffalo, and rhino — some new headliners are about to take the stage. Specialists Matt and Sophie share the all-star wildlife line-ups from India and Borneo.



Jungle VIP
Bornean orangutan in the jungle, Sepilok



India's Big Five

By India specialist Matt



Vast. That's the first word that comes to mind when I think of India. The second? Varied. This continent-sized country shifts at every turn, from snow-capped mountains to sun-baked plains to wetlands shrouded in fog. It's no surprise, then, that its wildlife is equally wide-ranging, shaped by these different environments. The result: a formidable safari line-up that rivals even Africa's heavyweights. The Bengal tiger, Asian elephant, Indian leopard, sloth bear, and greater one-horned rhino are the undisputed "Big Five" here. Better still, you can encounter them all across just two national parks: Tadoba and Dudhwa.

Over the years, I've had the privilege of visiting both reserves, beginning with Tadoba, around two hours' drive south of Nagpur in central India. Here, the first thing that strikes you is the dust. Great swathes of it billowed up from the dirt track as we bounced along in a 4x4. From March to May, my guide Anit told me, Tadoba takes on a distinctly yellow hue, with little rainfall and thinning teak forests exposing more of the earth. I remember thinking the wildlife should stick out like a sore thumb in this environment, but it was more subtle than that. "Like us, the animals enjoy their shade," Anit said, "and, as the dry season progresses, they're more and more drawn to the larger waterholes."

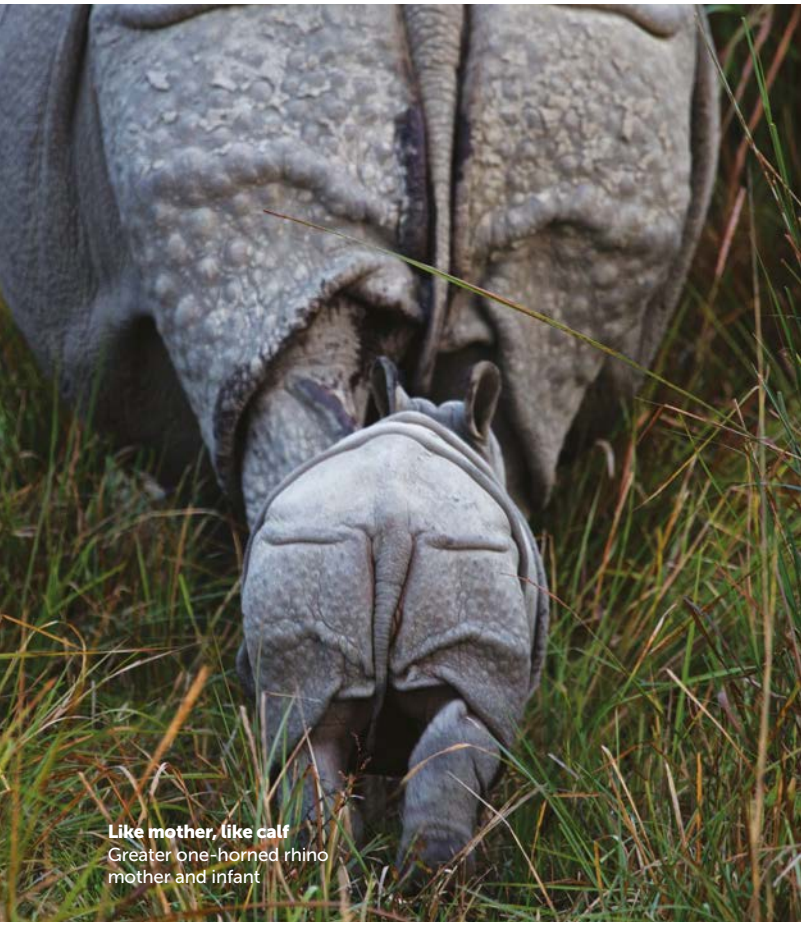
It didn't take long to see what he meant. Spotted deer, chausingha (a four-horned antelope), and a group of fruit-pinching langurs were some of the species we found congregating by the water. Yet it was en route back to our hotel that we first came across the park's star attraction, a Bengal tiger padding down the dirt track. "Tigers are often on the move, patrolling their territory, and the roads provide a more comfortable surface for their paws," Anit informed me.

With a strict permit system and zoning

> "The one before us in that moment was male — a huge hulking specimen with defined muscles shifting beneath its orange fur."



Tiger, tiger, burning bright
Bengal tiger, central India



Like mother, like calf
Greater one-horned rhino mother and infant



Hard to spot
Indian leopard

regulations in place, Tadoba receives fewer visitors than many of India's better-known parks, yet it boasts one of the country's healthiest tiger populations and some of its most consistent sightings. The one before us in that moment was male — a huge, hulking specimen with defined muscles shifting beneath its orange fur. It paid us no mind, nonchalantly passing by the 4x4 without even a glance. Meanwhile, we edged just a little further into our seats, content to give him plenty of room.

Leopards might be regarded as India's "second" big cat, but they're far more elusive than tigers, and, because of it, all the more rewarding to find. We were fortunate enough to spot one not long after our tiger encounter. She was draped across a tree branch, her rosette coat blending so seamlessly into the scenery I'd never have noticed her without our guide's keen eye.

Sloth bears are an even rarer sight. I've been to many parks in India without seeing one at all, but there's a large population in Tadoba, even if they're adept at staying in the shadows. The only time I spotted one was simply because my guide and I heard a rustle in the undergrowth. Seconds later, we were face-to-face with a rather dusty, shaggy-haired adult, who, when standing tall, was easily my height.

For the final two of India's Big Five, you need to venture into an entirely different landscape. Close to the Himalaya, Dudhwa National Park is defined by terai grasslands, wetland marshes, and dense sal woodland. The vegetation can easily grow taller than an elephant, which is just one reason they thrive in such numbers here. That, and the abundance of water.

I was fortunate enough to see several Asian elephants on my trip to Dudhwa last year, but it was the sight of a tusker breaking through the grass that I remember most. From poaching to genetics, there are a variety of explanations why it's rare to see a male bull with tusks in India, making this a particularly special sighting. We sat there for a good while as he went about his business, munching on the grass and swishing his tail, seemingly unbothered by our presence or the intense sun.

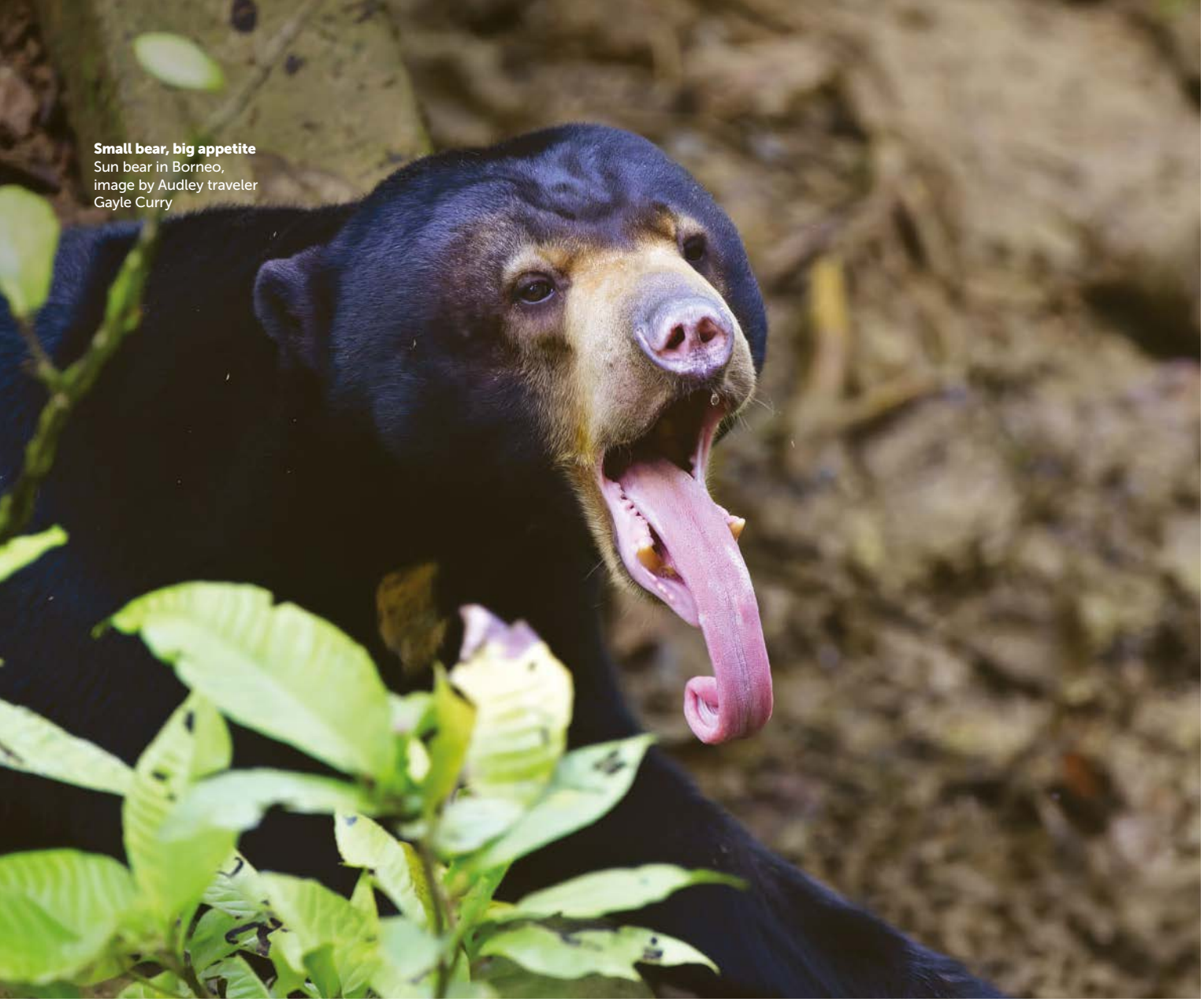
Another distinctive feature of Dudhwa is its birdwatching towers, which rise above the towering grass. As tall as a house, they offer a completely different perspective of the landscape, and I completed my India Big Five checklist from one of them. Binoculars raised to his eyes, my guide pointed toward something silvery lumbering through the overgrowth. The tank-like silhouette of a one-horned rhino quickly came into focus, but I wasn't expecting the dog-sized calf ambling along beside it. The youngster was dutifully following its mother, yet every so often, it would stop to take in the scenery, as fascinated by this world as we were.

Get me there

A 13-day trip for two to India, including time in Tadoba, Dudhwa, and the Golden Triangle, starts from $10,950pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our India specialists on **855-750-4065**.



Small bear, big appetite
Sun bear in Borneo, image by Audley traveler Gayle Curry

Borneo's Big Five

By Borneo specialist Sophie



Wildlife plays an enormous role in any visit to Borneo. Many of the animals that inhabit the rainforests are found nowhere else on Earth, and some are unlike anything else you'll ever see. For me, there are no better show-stealers than the island's Big Five: the orangutan, proboscis monkey, pygmy elephant, sun bear, and rhinoceros hornbill. And, the best way to encounter them? Following their trail through northern Sabah.

The village of Sepilok, a half-hour drive from the city of Sandakan, is the best place to start. You can't beat the excitement of seeing orangutans in the wild, but Sepilok Orangutan Rehabilitation Centre gives you the chance to see them up close. During feeding sessions, orangutans sweep down from the trees for their meal, often moving surprisingly quickly for such large primates. My advice? Stop by during the afternoon — it's much quieter as most visitors only stay in the area for one night so attend the morning feed instead.

Another of the Big Five is close at hand at the sun bear sanctuary next door. I explored it on a private tour with its founder, Dr Wong, who was eager to share his knowledge of the world's smallest bear. From a stilted platform, he pointed out each resident in the canopy below (they're enthusiastic tree climbers) by name and explained their individual personality quirks. You can also take a closer look using telescopic lenses set up around the site.

From Sepilok, your route into the jungle is the Kinabatangan River. I've been to Borneo many times, yet whenever I visit, the wildlife has never failed to amaze me. Kinabatangan Wetlands Resort is my recommended place to stay, as you can only reach it by boat, and there's only one other lodge in the area. This makes it quiet, and there's far less competition when it comes to wildlife spotting. I'm particularly fond of the guided night walks on the resort's boardwalks, where you can look for flying lemurs, frogs, and bearded pigs.

However, the main activity here is river cruising. And for good reason: the riverbanks are a magnet for wildlife. In fact, I've spotted two more of the Five here — troops of bulbous-nosed proboscis monkeys dangling from the trees and a seldom-seen rhinoceros hornbill, with its yellow-and-red bill, swooping overhead.

I suggest opting for a private boat and guide so your day can be tailored around

what you want to see. One of my guides, Dido, took me away from the main river channels down a narrow tributary. We stopped for an hour to watch a male orangutan build a nest up in the canopy.

Thinking I'd peaked with this experience, the next day we cruised to a spot he knew was popular with orangutans. We cut the engine, and after a short wait, we watched as a male emerged just across the river and slowly began to munch his way through the fruit on the trees. Suddenly, he let out an almighty call and swished away through the foliage, leaving the riverbank quiet once more.

For a totally different perspective on the forest, and your chance to round off the Big Five list, head out at dusk for a night safari. Sitting in the back of an open-top 4x4, we drove along trails surrounding the river, my guide armed with a light to illuminate any wildlife. We soon picked a civet's beady eyes out of the darkness, followed by deer, bearded pigs, a glimpse of a mouse, and then a herd of pygmy elephants emerging from the darkness and trampling through the undergrowth. I'd witnessed one of Borneo's great spectacles.

Get me there

You can visit Sepilok and the Kinabatangan River as part of an 11-day journey across Borneo. A trip for two starts from $4,180pp.

More inspiration

Speak to one of our Borneo specialists on **855-276-2860**.



Nature's celebrities (pictured) Two rhinoceros hornbills, image by Audley traveler Lynda Harding; (top right) Galapagos sea lion

"We cut the engine, and after a short wait, an orangutan emerged just across the river and slowly began to munch his way through the fruit on the trees."



"Fives" from around the world

The Galapagos Big Five:
You can spot the local Big Five — giant tortoise, marine iguana, blue-footed booby, Galapagos penguin, and sea lion — all in one place on Isabela Island.

Japan's Big Five:
On a trip across Japan's major islands, you might see Steller's sea eagles and red-crowned cranes soaring over Hokkaido, before observing the region's brown bears. Continuing south to Honshu, you can watch snow monkeys bathing in the hot springs of Jigokudani Onsen and come across Sika deer roaming Miyajima Island.

Africa's Little Five:
A safari in Kenya's Masai Mara offers far more besides sightings of lions, leopards, and elephants. Here, you can go in search of the Little Five on foot. Referencing Africa's Big Five, they comprise the elephant shrew, antlion, rhinoceros beetle, buffalo weaver, and leopard tortoise.

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Peak Patagonia
Lake Viedma and the surrounding pampas grasslands, backed by mountains

TWO SIDES TO...

Ascend to great heights in the Andes or dive below the surface for whale

When you think of Patagonia, your mind might paint a picture of gauchos on horseback sauntering over a wide expanse of amber plains. But there's so much more to this part of Argentina. The diversity of the landscapes and experiences on offer is vast, ranging from hiking towering peaks to whale watching off wild Atlantic beaches. Our Argentina specialists Ana and Luc share their ideas for exploring this region in two very different ways: getting active and basking in nature in El Chaltén, or exploring culture and wildlife on the untamed shores of Peninsula Valdés.

OUTDOOR ADVENTURES



By Argentina specialist Ana

The angular, snow-capped peaks of Mount Fitz Roy rise above the quaint town of El Chaltén in this mountainous realm of Argentinian Patagonia. Nestled at the foot of the Andes, the postage stamp-sized town — replete with rustic lodges and outdoors shops — serves as your base for exploring Los Glaciares National Park and its surrounds.

You can spend your days gazing at colossal blue glaciers, rafting through turbulent rapids on the Rio de las Vueltas, or hiking trails of varying intensities that offer ever-changing vistas.

This playground for outdoor adventure will appeal to anyone who likes trekking, and you don't have to be a pro mountain climber to partake. The staff at your hotel will be able to book a guide for you or provide maps for self-guided hikes. The latter is a popular option thanks to the well-marked routes, many with trailheads originating in the town itself.

The hike to Laguna de los Tres ranks among the most difficult, so if you're a less-experienced hiker, I recommend having a guide to lead the way. As you follow the trail, you'll see the landscape of Patagonia change from leafy woodlands to rugged slate-grey foothills, with snowy peaks beckoning in the distance.

At the summit, your hard work's rewarded with an unfettered view of Mount Fitz Roy's three peaks reflecting in the gleaming turquoise lake below. With a refreshing mountain breeze to cool you down and nothing but the sounds of nature, it's easy to feel at one with the elements.

If you'd prefer an easier ramble, the path to Laguna Azul takes you through a private nature reserve to the aptly named "blue lake", eventually revealing a lesser-seen view of Mount Fitz Roy's north face.

At the end of the day, you can rest your legs at one of El Chaltén's lodges. I like Chalten Suites or Destino Sur Hotel & Spa de Montaña. Both are adorned in wooden planks and cut stone to evoke the atmosphere of the wild lands they inhabit.

The Southern Patagonian Ice Field stretches alongside El Chaltén on the Chile–Argentina border, and there are multiple ways to experience glaciers during your trip. Walk through a moss-green forest to emerge at Huemul Glacier, which sweeps down the hillside to a clear alpine lake. Motor across Lake Viedma by boat, passing sheer icy cliffs while listening out for ice calving from the massive Viedma Glacier — the crackling sound seems to reverberate for miles. Or don crampons for a trek over Cagliero Glacier.

To reach El Chaltén, you'll arrive via the airport in El Calafate, and I recommend spending a few nights there, too, so you can visit the nearby Perito Moreno Glacier.

If you're still craving a taste of the gaucho lifestyle, you can journey from El Chaltén to a remote Patagonian estancia. Saddle up for a horseback ride across the fertile grasslands and fuel up after a day of exploration with an asado (a traditional Argentinian barbecue), with beef sourced locally from the pampas.



Penguins & tea parties
(pictured) Magellanic penguins, Peninsula Valdés; (below) traditional Welsh cakes

PATAGONIA

watching: which Patagonia will you choose?

WILDLIFE & CULTURE



By Argentina specialist Luc
If you prefer sandals to hiking boots, perhaps the marine life, natural history, and distinct culture of Peninsula Valdés will be more your speed. The opposite of mountainous El Chaltén, here you'll see pancake-flat plateaux of semi-arid scrublands sprawling toward the coast.

Jutting out into the Atlantic, Peninsula Valdés is a little knuckle of terra firma. It's attached to Argentina by a sliver of land surrounded by two protected gulfs. These bodies of water are an important breeding ground for southern right whales, sea lions, elephant seals, and orcas.

A full-day tour takes you to wild beaches, where you can walk among sunbathing seals and short-necked Magellanic penguins in their natural habitats. The high-pitched squawks (and surprisingly strong smell) of the penguins radiate from their immense colonies — Punta Tombo is home to 400,000 of the aquatic birds at the peak of hatching season.

And for a glimpse of wildlife that's long-gone, I can arrange a behind-the-scenes tour of the dinosaur bones on show at the Museo Paleontológico Egidio Feruglio in Trelew for you.

Back in the great outdoors, you can seek out whales by boarding a semi-submersible whale-watching boat. Take in the ocean breeze from the top deck for some classic whale watching, then head down into the submarine section on the lower deck, where 40 picture-box windows frame the view. The curious whales often come right up to the glass.

The boat departs from Puerto Pirámides — the only town in Peninsula Valdés. There isn't a huge number of hotels to choose from here, but I recommend Las Restingas Hotel de Mar. It's quite a simple property, but it sits right on the beachfront. I'll book you into one of the upstairs rooms, where you can keep your eyes peeled for whales from your balcony.

I think September is the sweet spot for visiting the region. While southern right whales pass through from June to December, the sea becomes too murky from October onward for a fish's-eye view of the creatures. Plus, September is the start of penguin season as the colonies arrive to grow their monochromatic flocks.

Speaking of colonies and whales — well, Wales — the Valdés area is known as "Welsh Patagonia" after the settlers who arrived here in the late 1800s. And it's not just a thing of the past. There's still a contingent of Welsh speakers in the region.



While you're in the area, I recommend visiting Gaiman, a town that still has a large Welsh community. As a contrast to the Argentine cuisine you'll try during your trip, go to Ty Gwyn Tearoom, where you can tuck into a selection of cakes, mini sandwiches, and bread topped with strawberry jam and rich clotted cream.

Get me there:

A 12-day trip for two that takes in Peninsula Valdés starts from $14,995pp, while an 11-day trip for two, including Los Glaciares, starts from $8,550pp.

View trip ideas

FROM YOU

Letters, photos from your travels, and questions for our specialists: we love hearing from you.

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"We went to Antarctica and loved it so much that we'd love to return. What could we do a second time around?"

JAMES, VIA INSTAGRAM



Antarctica specialist Nik says:
There are a few ways to unlock new facets of the Antarctic. I suggest visiting during another part of the season to see different wildlife. From November to mid-December, pristine snow is the stage for pebble exchanges as gentoo penguins seek mates, while their chicks start hatching from the end of December. By February, the colonies begin to thin out, but you can see humpback whales and their calves as they come to feed. It's also the best time to voyage into the Weddell Sea, where you can see huge tabular icebergs. If your first trip was a while back, you'll find a wider variety of experiences now, with kayaking, ice camping, and helicopter rides straight from the ship.



Read all about it

"I didn't set out to write a book. It started with me blogging my daily observations while traveling, commenting on the downright surprising aspects of exploring the ways of the world in almost 140 countries. This included many trips provided by Audley to destinations few other companies were prepared to facilitate travel to. And, before I knew it, there was a book's worth."

Jeremy Burton





Drawing Kyoto

"I sketch when I travel. Drawing helps me focus and anchors the memory of a place or experience. For our recent trip to Japan, my wife, Christine, and I asked Japan specialist Tamatha to guide us to places that would be visually rich. In Kyoto, we had a dinner with a maiko (trainee geisha), sitting at a small bar while the chef prepared our meal. I was captivated by the geisha who came to pour our sake, and the chef noticed me sketching and — unexpectedly — invited me to draw on his wall. I always carry a small sketchbook, pens, and pencils, which were portable enough for our bike tour in the old city. We stopped in Kyoto Botanical Gardens, where I drew a group of women dressed in kimono having a picnic on the Central Lawn. And one afternoon, I wandered off alone to draw the sacred gates at the Yasaka Shrine. Those Kyoto memories remain so clear... embedded in my drawings."

Bill Russell



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